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HOW TO SOLVE THE CONUNDRUM OF ADOLESCENT AUTONOMY?

On the importance of distinguishing between independence and volitional functioning

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This chapter focuses on a distinction between two conceptualizations of autonomy and the relevance of this distinction for adolescent development. Specifically, we discuss theory and research dealing with autonomy-as-independence (i.e., the degree to which adolescents are self-reliant and make decisions without input from others) and autonomy-as-volition (i.e., the degree to which adolescents regulate their behavior based on deeply held values, preferences, and interests). We argue that this distinction helps to provide nuanced answers to controversial questions related to adolescent autonomy. Specifically, we revisit six questions about adolescent autonomy in light of the distinction between independence and volition. Throughout the chapter, we highlight the complex interplay between the two conceptualizations of autonomy and we call for future research addressing their combined and interactive role in adolescent development.

Free from what? What does that matter to Zarathustra! But your fiery eyes should tell me: free for what?

Nietzsche, Also Sprach Zarathustra

Psychologists, philosophers, economists, and sociologists have devoted literally thousands of books, papers, and talks to the topic of autonomy. Scholars have debated about several issues related to autonomy, many of which deal with the question whether autonomy is always beneficial or whether instead its effects depend on factors such as timing (What if people achieve autonomy too early?), quantity (Can people be too autonomous?), and cultural context (Is autonomy only a good thing in the West?). These questions have received much attention specifically in regard to adolescent development because adolescence is considered a developmental period during which establishing a sense of autonomy is a key developmental task (Steinberg and Morris, 2001; Zimmer-Gembeck and Collins, 2003). In spite of a broad consensus about the centrality of autonomy to understanding adolescents' functioning, there is much controversy about the exact meaning of autonomy, about its role in adolescent development, and about the way socializing agents can foster healthy autonomy development.

The psychological literature has witnessed a proliferation of jargon related to the notion of autonomy. Autonomy has been used interchangeably with many more different terms, including constructs such as independence, volition, willingness, ownership, freedom, choice, self-reliance, uniqueness, self-sufficiency, and even egoism, narcissism, defiance, and rebellion. As a result, the concept of autonomy has become blurred and fuzzy. This conceptual confusion also hampered the precise assessment of autonomy. There has been an upsurge in the development of autonomy-related measures, with some measures receiving similar labels while measuring different aspects of autonomy and with other measures having different labels but tapping into similar content (Van Petegem, Vansteenkiste, and Beyers, 2013).

In recent years, theory and research have begun to demonstrate the importance of distinguishing between two broad conceptualizations of autonomy, one of which has to do with self-reliance and independence from others and one of which has to do with the regulation of behavior on the basis of deeply endorsed values, preferences, and interests (Ryan and Lynch, 1989; Soenens et al., 2007). We will refer to this distinction as a distinction between independence and volitional functioning. In this chapter we will argue that this distinction can bring much clarity to a complex area of research. The first section of this chapter deals with the conceptual distinction between independence and volitional functioning. The second section deals with six specific and controversial issues related to adolescent autonomy, and we examine how the distinction between independence and volitional functioning can help to shed a refreshing light on these issues.

Two prevalent—but different—perspectives on autonomy in adolescent psychology

Autonomy as independence

In mainstream adolescent psychology, autonomy is traditionally defined as independence or self-reliance; that is, the extent to which one behaves, decides, or thinks without relying on others (Goossens, 2006; Steinberg, 2002). The opposite of autonomy then involves dependence or reliance on others, and on the parents in particular. This viewpoint is rooted in Separation-Individuation Theory (Blos, 1979), which implies that a normative developmental task for adolescents is to relinquish and transcend an idealized and immature view of their parents and to reduce the psychological dependence on parents' approval. When occurring smoothly, this normative process of separation-individuation would result in more *independent* decision-making, with adolescents taking more decisions by themselves, particularly in the personal domain (e.g., choice of clothing and friendships; Smetana et al., Campione-Barr, and Daddis, 2004; Smetana, Chapter 3, this volume). In addition to this behavioral component, autonomy according to Separation-Individuation Theory also would manifest at the *emotional* and *functional* level (Hoffman, 1984). Emotional independence is defined as an adolescent's freedom from excessive need for approval and emotional support by parents. Functional independence refers to the extent to which one is capable of managing practical affairs without soliciting parental help.

The developmental challenge for adolescents is not to detach themselves from their attachment figures, yet, to transform the hierarchical parent-child relation into a more horizontal one. Throughout this transformation process, a crucial task for adolescents is to strive towards more independent functioning while at the same time maintaining positive relations with parents (e.g., Cooper and Grotevant, 2011; Grotevant and Cooper, 1986; Youniss and Smollar, 1985). In other words, this gradual process towards increased independence should take place in a supportive context. Research indeed shows that adolescents who display assertiveness and independence in family discussions while simultaneously staying connected to parents display better psychosocial adjustment, as reflected for instance in higher self-esteem, social competence in friendships, and high-quality romantic relationships (Allen, Hauser, Bell, and O'Connor, 1994; Hauser et al., 1984; Kansky et al., Chapter 2, this volume; Oudekerk, Allen, Hessel, and Molloy, 2015).

The pursuit of an optimal balance between the striving for independence and the maintenance of satisfying parent-child relationships can also go awry (Blos, 1979; Levy-Warren, 1999; Mahler and Furer, 1963). Disturbances in the healthy separation-individuation process might have to do with a failure to achieve independence or with a failure to stay well-connected to the caregiver (Kins, Beyers, and Soenens, 2013; Lapsley, Rice, and Shadid, 1989; McClanahan and Holmbeck, 1992). In the case of dysfunctional independence, an adolescent's striving for independence comes at the cost of a close attachment relationship. In other words, these

adolescents tend to detach themselves from socialization figures, as the caregivers engender feelings of rejection, alienation, and mistrust (Beyers et al., 2003). As adolescents become excessively concerned with demonstrating their self-reliance, they may even display oppositional defiance to the parents' authority, in which case any external interference is perceived as a potential threat for one's striving towards independence (Van Petegem, Vansteenkiste, Soenens, Beyers, and Aelterman, 2015). Alternatively, disturbances in the separation-individuation process might also entail dysfunctional dependence, as manifested through separation anxiety (Wood, 2006). For separation-anxious individuals, the separation from attachment figures represents a threat to the relation and, hence, causes intense distress, loneliness, and fear of being abandoned.

Autonomy as volitional functioning

Other theories have conceptualized autonomy in terms of volitional functioning. A prominent theory in this regard is Self-Determination Theory (SDT; Deci and Ryan, 2000, 2016; Ryan and Deci, 2000; Vansteenkiste, Niemiec, and Soenens, 2010), a general theory on motivation, personality, and social development in which the concept of autonomy takes a central place. Two concepts in SDT are specifically relevant to the notion of autonomy as volition; that is, the basic psychological need for autonomy and autonomous motivation.

Need for autonomy. Together with the basic psychological needs for relatedness and competence, the need for autonomy is considered an essential ingredient for growth, integration, and well-being (Ryan and Deci, 2000). When satisfied, this need manifests in feelings of psychological freedom and authenticity. In contrast, when frustrated it entails experiences of heteronomy; that is, feelings of pressure and inner conflict (Ryan, Deci, and Vansteenkiste, 2016). SDT makes strong claims about the importance of this psychological need, stating that it is a fundamental and universal need essential to all individuals' thriving and psychosocial adjustment.

Consistent with these strong claims, there is solid evidence that satisfaction of the need for autonomy is related to higher levels of general well-being and to domain-specific adjustment, both in adults and in adolescents (Deci and Ryan, 2016; Vansteenkiste and Ryan, 2013). For instance, research with adolescents has shown that autonomy need satisfaction is related to developmental outcomes such as well-being (Cordeiro, Paixão, Lens, Lacante, and Luyckx, 2016; Veronneau, Koestner, and Abela, 2005), healthy identity development (Luyckx, Vansteenkiste, Goossens, and Duriez, 2009), physical activity (Gunnell, Bélanger, and Brunet, 2016), and quality of sleep (Campbell et al., 2015). In contrast, frustration of the need for autonomy is related to greater maladjustment and risk for psychopathology (Ryan, Deci, and Vansteenkiste, 2016), stress (Bartholomew, Ntoumanis, Ryan, Bosch, and Thogerson-Ntoumani, 2011), internalizing and externalizing problems (Costa, Cuzzocrea, Gugliandolo, and Larcán, 2016; Mabbe, Soenens, Vansteenkiste and Van Leeuwen, 2016), eating disorder symptoms (Boone, Vansteenkiste, Soenens,

van der Kaap-Deeder, and Verstuyf, 2014), bullying (Fousiani, Dimitropoulou, Michaelides, and Van Petegem, 2016), and pathological internet use (Liu, Fang, Wan, and Zhou, 2016).

Autonomous motivation. Besides the need for autonomy, the SDT-based concept of autonomous motivation is also relevant. In SDT, autonomous motivation refers to self-endorsed reasons for engaging in an activity or for pursuing a particular goal (Deci and Ryan, 2000). When they are autonomously motivated, people engage in an activity willingly. This is because the activity is inherently satisfying and interesting (i.e., intrinsic motivation) or because people see the personal value of engaging in the activity (i.e., identification). Thus, even when an activity is not inherently enjoyable or challenging (such as following a rule), people can still internalize its importance, thereby experiencing greater ownership over the behavior and displaying autonomous motivation. Autonomous motivation can be contrasted with controlled motivation, which occurs when people feel pressured either by external forces (e.g., threats of punishment and certain types of rewards) or by internal demands (e.g., to avoid feelings of shame or guilt, or to boost one's self-worth) to do something or to pursue a certain goal. Instead of wanting to do an activity (as with autonomous motivation), with controlled motivation people are investing effort because they have to (Ryan and Deci, 2000; Vansteenkiste et al., 2010).

Abundant research has demonstrated the adaptive value of autonomous motivation in diverse areas of individuals' lives, including work (Gagné and Deci, 2005), sports (Pelletier, Fortier, Vallerand, and Briere, 2001), and religious behavior (Ryan, Rigby, and King, 1993) to name a few. Research with adolescents has shown that autonomous motivation is important in domains such as school work and social relationships. For instance, autonomous academic motivation is related to the use of more deep-level strategies for learning, higher competence, and ultimately to higher school grades (Grolnick, Kurowski, Dunlap, and Hevey, 2000; Vansteenkiste, Zhou, Lens, and Soenens, 2005). Similarly, adolescents with more autonomous motives for engaging in friendships were found to experience more social competence (Soenens and Vansteenkiste, 2005).

Theoretically, the need for autonomy, which speaks to the energetic basis of individuals' behavior, and autonomous motivation, which represents the motivational direction of people's functioning, are assumed to be reciprocally related. Specifically, satisfaction of the need for autonomy provides the impetus and psychological flexibility required for autonomous motivation to unfold. That is, when people experience a sense of volition and choice when carrying out activities, they are more likely to develop and maintain autonomous motivation for a given activity and they may orient behavior towards engagement in enjoyable or highly valued activities. Indeed, intrinsically motivating activities function as a magnet to which people get naturally attracted when they experience a sense of volition and psychological freedom. At the same time, when people engage in activities or pursue goals for self-endorsed reasons, they are more likely to experience a sense of authenticity

and psychological freedom, as their actions are fully endorsed by the self and are in line with one's personal convictions and values. That is, autonomy need satisfaction may be the very outcome of engaging in an activity for autonomous reasons (e.g., Chen, Beyers, Vansteenkiste, Soenens, and Van Petegem, 2013; Sheldon and Kasser, 1998). Because autonomous motivation and satisfaction of the need for autonomy reinforce one another mutually, they can both be considered key indicators of volitional functioning.

Contrasting the notions of independence and volitional functioning

Differentiation. Increasingly, theory and research point to the importance of differentiating clearly between independence and volitional functioning (Ryan et al., 2016). Independence is mainly about the question how much adolescents depend on others and who is regulating a certain behavior or goal (i.e., the parent, the adolescent, or both) (Ryan and Lynch, 1989); in other words, it is mainly defined in interpersonal terms. In contrast, volitional functioning is more about within-person concordance; that is, about the degree to which behaviors or goals are aligned with one's deeply held values, preferences, and interests (Sheldon and Elliot, 1999). When behavior and goals are concordant with these values and interests, people experience a sense of psychological freedom and authenticity. The opposite of volitional functioning is heteronomy, which manifests in feelings of being pressured to take a certain course of action of being alienated from who one really is (Ryan and Deci, 2000).

Because the dimension contrasting independence with dependence is distinct from the dimension contrasting volitional functioning with pressured (heteronomous) functioning, both dimensions can be crossed, resulting in four possible positions. As Figure 1.1 illustrates, adolescents can experience volition both when they act independently and when they are in a dependent position vis-à-vis their parents. For instance, an adolescent can make a decision about her study choice without much input from parents because she is in touch with her preferences and knows quite well what she wants to do. This adolescent chooses to make an independent choice, thereby displaying volitional independence. Another adolescent could choose to consult his parents because they provide valuable input and because he appreciates his parents' opinion. As he chooses to rely on his parents' advice, he is in a position of volitional dependence. This position is akin to the concept of emotional reliance, which refers to individuals' willing reliance on others for emotional support (Ryan, La Guardia, Solky-Butzel, Chirkov, and Kim, 2005).

In a parallel way, adolescents can be heteronomous and, consequently, experience pressure and coercion both in situations of independence and in situations of dependence. When parents consider study choices as personal decisions that every person has to make for himself or when they are not available to provide input, an adolescent has no other option but to make an independent decision. He feels pressured to make this independent decision because he is left to his own devices. Conversely, parents may convey that they know what is best for their child, thereby

pressuring the adolescent to follow the parents' advice. In the case of controlled dependence, adolescents feel forced to depend on parents for advice, assistance, and support.

Several recent studies confirmed the validity of the distinction between independence (versus dependence) and volition (versus pressure) during adolescence. Van Petegem et al. (2013) administered an elaborate battery of autonomy-related measures in two large samples of adolescents and found that these measures could be best represented in a two-dimensional space, with the two retained dimensions reflecting independence and volition. Importantly, in each of the four quadrants, a number of autonomy-relevant concepts and measures could be located, suggesting that many contemporary "autonomy" measures reflect a combination of both viewpoints on autonomy. Hence, this study indicates that the independence-volition distinction is critical to bring structure and clarity in the landscape of autonomy-relevant concepts and measures.

In another study, Van Petegem, Beyers, Vansteenkiste, and Soenens (2012) focused specifically on independent decision-making, which serves as one marker of independence. Specifically, using the Family Decision Making Scale (Dornbusch et al., 1985), they assessed the degree to which adolescents made independent decisions about 20 issues (e.g., what clothes to wear, whether you can hang out with friends your parents don't like). While decisions made by parents alone reflected high dependency, decisions made by adolescents without input from parents reflected independence. In addition, adolescents also scored their autonomous (or volitional) and controlled (or pressured) reasons both for making independent decisions and for depending on their parents. As such, apart from a quantitative indicator of independent decision-making as such, the authors also obtained a measure reflecting the type or quality of reasons for acting (in)dependently. Results confirmed that the degree to which adolescents make dependent or independent decisions was clearly distinct from the underlying motivation for doing so. Moreover, in both studies, adolescents' volitional functioning consistently related to higher emotional well-being and better behavioral adjustment, regardless of whether adolescents decided independently or were dependent on their parents. In contrast, adolescents' degree of independent functioning was virtually unrelated to well-being and was even related positively to problem behaviors such as alcohol abuse (Van Petegem et al., 2012, 2013).

The interplay between independence and volition. Although Figure 1.1 may create the impression that independence and volition constitute orthogonal concepts, this is not the case. Associations between independence and volitional functioning are typically positive. For instance, adolescents displayed more volitional motives for deciding independently about issues than for leaving decisions about these issues to parents (Van Petegem et al., 2012). These findings suggest that, at least in Western societies, situations of independence provide relatively more room for volitional functioning, possibly because such situations provide more opportunity for expressing one's personal preferences, values, and interests in these situations.

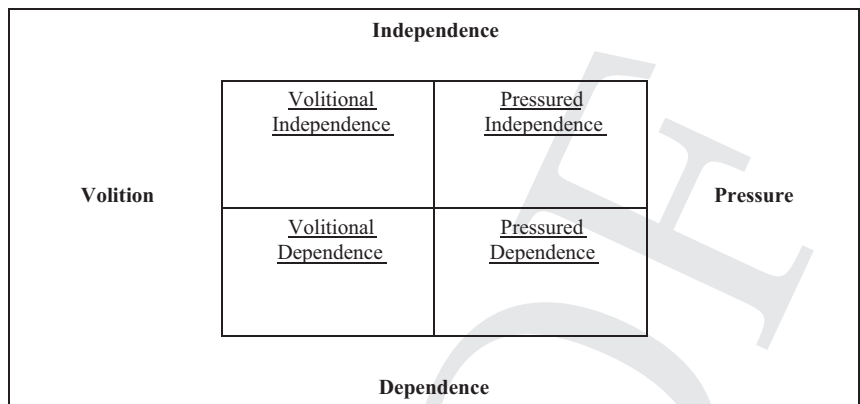


FIGURE 1.1 Graphical representation of the distinction between independence and volitional functioning

The finding that independence and volition are related positively suggests that, instead of pitting the two conceptualizations of autonomy against each other, a more fruitful approach is to examine their dynamic interplay. Longitudinal research could address bidirectional associations between both types of autonomy. Possibly, experiences of volition may generate energy necessary for adolescents to take initiative, to explore different options and lifestyles, and to function more independently. At the same time, independence may also give rise to more volitional functioning across time. Note that for adolescents to function independently, not only does their need for volition need to be nurtured, but they also need to feel sufficiently competent and confident such that they more easily trust the decisions they make by themselves. Also, a strong sense of connection with parents (resulting in relatedness need satisfaction) may be critical, such that satisfaction of all three psychological needs assumed in SDT may be implied in adolescents' independence and, more specifically, in their volitional (self-endorsed) regulation of independence (Chen et al., 2013).

Apart from its dynamic interplay, future research also could examine the conditions under which volitional independence is most likely to surface. For instance, relying on Social Domain Theory (Nucci, 2013; Smetana, Jambon, and Ball, 2013; Smetana, Chapter 3, this volume), it can be predicted that adolescents display more volitional independence with regard to personal issues, which reflect adolescents' self-expression and personal identity (e.g., which music to listen to, and how to decorate one's room). In contrast, when it comes to issues about which parents have legitimate authority (e.g., health-related issues and moral issues), adolescents may display more volitional dependence, accepting more easily their parents' advice and support.

Thus, rather than considering the four quadrants in Figure 1.1 as stable, disposition-like orientations, future research would do well to examine domain-specific differences in these orientations within adolescents' functioning, as well as adolescents' capacity to flexibly switch between orientations depending on the

domain involved. While volitional independence might be more common and adaptive in some domains, volitional dependence might be more adaptive in other domains. Still, it is important to bear in mind that, on the basis of SDT (Ryan and Lynch, 1989; Soenens and Vansteenkiste, 2010), the two volitional orientations are assumed to yield more adaptive outcomes than the two pressured orientations (Van Petegem et al., 2012, 2013).

Summary. There is increasing evidence for a distinction between independence and volitional functioning, with both types of autonomy displaying differential associations with adolescents' adjustment. While independence yields a mixed pattern of adjustment outcomes (e.g., generally relating positively to well-being, yet also predicting higher levels of problem behavior), volitional functioning is a rather consistent predictor of better personal and social adjustment. Importantly, however, both types of autonomy are related positively, an observation that calls for future research about the intricate interplay among these types of autonomy.

Revisiting fundamental questions about autonomy in adolescent development

Armed with the conceptual distinction between independence and volitional functioning, in this second part of the chapter we revisit six controversial questions regarding the role of autonomy in adolescent development and regarding the role of socialization figures (mainly parents) in fostering autonomy. These six questions are displayed graphically in Figure 1.2. As shown in this figure, one question (represented by the timeline at the bottom of the figure) deals with autonomy

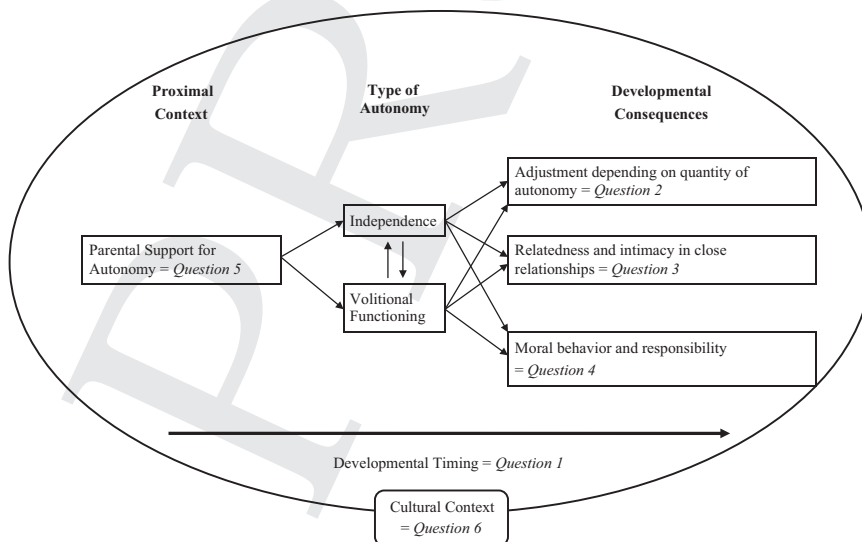


FIGURE 1.2 Graphical representation of the six questions addressed in this chapter

as a lifespan issue. Three questions deal with the developmental consequences of autonomy. Finally, two questions pertain to contextual influences on autonomy, highlighting the role of parents and the broader culture. Specifically, we address the questions (a) whether autonomy is relevant mainly during specific life periods such as adolescence or whether it is crucial throughout the lifespan; (b) whether autonomy needs to be dosed carefully to engender well-being or whether there are no limits to the benefits of autonomy; (c) whether autonomy represents a potential threat to individuals' relational functioning or whether being autonomous and building intimate relations go hand in hand; (d) whether the pursuit of autonomy is at odds with morality or whether autonomous functioning is a pathway to morally responsible behavior; (e) whether parents need to give up on rules to maximize individuals' sense of autonomy; and (f) whether autonomy represents a universal ingredient of wellness or whether autonomy is only beneficial for individuals living in more individualistic societies.

12+: Should autonomy, like movies, receive an age rating?

Autonomy as independence. A common assumption in developmental psychology is that autonomy represents a developmental task. Key steps towards autonomy would be taken during fairly specific sensitive periods, the two most important ones of which are toddlerhood and adolescence. These are the two developmental periods characterized by an inclination for children to renegotiate the power balance in parent–child relationships, which possibly results in at least temporary increases of conflict and separation between parents and children. This age-bounded view on autonomy is particularly relevant when autonomy is defined as independence, which indeed requires that children take distance from parents and become more self-reliant. Consistent with this view, several studies have shown that adolescence is characterized by a rather sharp increase in separation from parents (Beyers, 2001; Chang, McBride–Chang, Stewart, and Au, 2003), less disclosure and more concealment in parent–child conversations (e.g., Laird, Marrero, Melching, and Kuhn, 2013), and more independent decision-making (Smetana et al., 2004; Wray-Lake, Crouter, and McHale, 2010).

Given that adolescence constitutes a sensitive period for the development of autonomy (understood as independence), it has also been argued that autonomy would be beneficial only within a certain window of time. That is, autonomy would foster adjustment only when it develops at an age appropriate for this developmental task. Both when autonomy is pursued or achieved too early and when it is achieved too late, children might be at risk for developmental problems (Steinberg and Silverberg, 1986). This argument is consistent with stage–environment fit theory (Eccles et al., 1993), according to which the affordance of autonomy by the social environment is beneficial only when it occurs at a time when children desire and search to establish autonomy (i.e., independence). Consistent with this reasoning, Dishion, Nelson, and Bullock (2004) showed that when parents disengage from

monitoring and regulation too early (leaving adolescents in a position of premature independence), their sons are more likely to engage in antisocial behavior.

Autonomy as volition. The notion that autonomy and the contextual affordance of autonomy would be beneficial only at a time when children express a desire for autonomy makes sense when autonomy is understood as independence. However, when autonomy is conceptualized as volitional functioning, different predictions can be made about the role of autonomy across different life periods. From the SDT perspective, autonomy is considered a fundamental and inherent human need, the satisfaction of which would be essential for people to grow and thrive *across* the lifespan (Ryan and Deci, 2000; Ryan et al., 2016).

These SDT-based claims about the age-invariant importance of volitional functioning are receiving increasing empirical support. There is evidence that satisfaction of the basic psychological needs, including the need for autonomy, is related to well-being not only among adolescents but also among elementary school children from Grade 4 onwards (Emery, Toste, and Heath, 2015; Veronneau et al., 2005; Van der Kaap-Deeder, Vansteenkiste, Soenens, and Mabbe, in press). Although it is difficult to have children report on their experiences of need satisfaction at an even younger age, research addressing contextual support of the need for autonomy (e.g., by parents) suggests that the need for autonomy is vitally important already from the first years of life. Parental support for volition during infancy has been shown to predict various important developmental outcomes, including mastery orientation (Grolnick, Frodi, and Bridges, 1984), secure attachment (Whipple, Bernier, and Mageau, 2011), executive functioning (Bernier, Carlson, and Whipple, 2010), and subsequent achievement later in life, even through high school (Bindman, Pomerantz, and Roisman, 2015).

Rather than assuming a short sensitive period in which autonomy plays a prominent role, in SDT it is assumed that people have a tendency to move towards greater levels of integration, thereby gradually displaying more volitional functioning as they grow older. That is, with increasing age, people would be more capable to bring ongoing experiences in harmony with their values, interests, and preferences (Ryan et al., 2016). Confirming this reasoning, adolescents have been found to increasingly display volitional functioning (Van Petegem, Vansteenkiste et al., 2015). This movement towards more volitional functioning does not stop after adolescence but seems to continue, under supportive circumstances, throughout the lifespan. For instance, with increasing age, adults display more self-endorsed reasons for pursuing goals (Sheldon and Kasser, 2001) and for engaging in non-enjoyable activities such as voting and paying taxes (Sheldon, Kasser, Houser-Marko, Jones, and Turban, 2005). Such findings suggests that that people continue to display increases in autonomy (defined as volition) beyond adolescence and into adulthood and that growth in autonomy is not the privilege of adolescents.

Does this mean that, from the perspective of SDT, there is nothing specific or developmental about the need for autonomy during adolescence? No. The manifestation of this need may indeed be affected by the specific developmental challenges

characteristic of adolescence. Most importantly, adolescence is a key developmental period for identity formation (Erikson, 1968; Kroger and Marcia, 2011), a developmental challenge with important repercussions for autonomy and at the same time a challenge strongly affected by autonomy-relevant dynamics (La Guardia, 2009; Ryan and Deci, 2003; Soenens and Vansteenkiste, 2011; Assor, Chapter 6, this volume). Hence, from the SDT perspective, identity development is one key developmental manifestation of volitional functioning during adolescence. At every age, there are different challenges to autonomy.

Intermediate summary. In conclusion, the notion that autonomy is relevant mainly during specific developmental phases such as adolescence applies only when autonomy is viewed as independence. In this case, the development of autonomy is said to represent an age-bounded developmental task, with adolescence representing a period of rapid increases in independence. However, when conceptualized as volitional functioning, autonomy is relevant across the lifespan. That is, adults increasingly display increasing volitional functioning across the lifespan, presumably because they are better in touch with their interests, values, and identities.

Is autonomy healthy only in moderate doses?

Autonomy as independence. Paralleling the idea that autonomy may develop too early or too late, developmental scholars have argued that both adolescents displaying too little autonomy as well as those displaying too much autonomy are at risk for developmental problems (Steinberg and Silverberg, 1986). For adolescents to develop well, they would need to seek an *optimal level* of autonomy, which is situated in between the two extreme ends of the continuum. Empirically, this hypothesis comes down to examining curvilinear associations between autonomy and adolescent adjustment and demonstrating that intermediate levels of autonomy are related to the most optimal pattern of adjustment.

A number of studies have taken this hypothesis to the test and some of these studies have provided evidence for the anticipated curvilinear association (Kurdek and Fine, 1994; Olweus, 1980). For instance, Harris-McKoy (2016) showed that adolescents displayed the lowest levels of delinquency when they reported moderate levels of parental decision-making. Both when parents were rated high on decision-making (reflecting low opportunities for adolescent autonomy) and when parents were rated low on decision-making (reflecting very high levels of adolescent autonomy), scores for delinquency were elevated. Such findings suggest that autonomy, like medication, should come with a leaflet warning adolescents and parents about the dangers of an overdose.

Matters are complicated further by research showing that the optimal level of autonomy-as-independence also depends on contextual influences. High levels of independence would be particularly detrimental in high-risk environments, where parental supervision and regulation would be needed to safeguard adolescents against threats and risks (Beyers and Goossens, 1999, 2003; Mason, Cauce, Gonzales,

and Hiraga, 1996). Adolescents exposed to deviant peer influences and adolescents living in dangerous neighborhoods appear to benefit most from at least moderate levels of parental rules and restrictions (Mason et al., 1996; Walker-Barnes and Mason, 2001). Such findings can be interpreted as meaning that very high levels of adolescent autonomy-as-independence, as indicated by a lack of parental rule-setting, create a risk for behavioral problems, particularly in high-risk conditions.

Autonomy as volition. Clearly, these arguments for a dosed display of autonomy are based on a conceptualization of autonomy as independence and, more specifically, on a definition of autonomy as *freedom from* parental rules, restrictions, and decision-making (i.e., negative freedom). When conceptualizing autonomy as volitional functioning, there is less reason to expect that the benefits of autonomy are limited. Because SDT assumes that autonomy represents a fundamental human need, it simply predicts a linear and positive association between autonomy and well-being (Ryan and Deci, 2000). The more people feel that they can be themselves, that they “own their actions,” and that they prioritize activities and goals that correspond to their values and interests, the better for their well-being.

Unfortunately, to the best of our knowledge, only few studies addressed empirically the question whether very high levels of volitional functioning are harmful. Research has documented systematic linear associations between volitional functioning and adolescents’ adjustment but has not identified curvilinear associations. Indirectly relevant to this issue are results from diary studies showing that daily experiences of autonomy need satisfaction contribute to individuals’ well-being even when taking into account interindividual differences in autonomy need satisfaction (Ryan, Bernstein, and Brown, 2010; Sheldon, Ryan, and Reis, 1996). These findings suggest that, over and above relatively stable between-person levels of autonomy need satisfaction, a daily surplus of autonomy adds to individuals’ well-being.

Further, when conceptualizing autonomy as volition, there is no evidence that (too much) autonomy would be harmful in populations of adolescents at risk for problem behavior. Stated differently, youngsters at risk would not benefit from an environment that externally controls their volition. In a sample of adolescent girls at risk for emotional and behavioral problems, Savard, Joussemet, Pelletier, and Mageau (2013) showed that a volition-promoting approach to introduce a workshop (learning adolescents to engage in constructive interpersonal problem-solving) led to increased valuation and liking of the workshop and to decreased ill-being. Relatedly, Van Petegem, Soenens, Vansteenkiste, and Beyers (2015, Study 3) found, in a sample of adolescent boys referred for antisocial behavior, that a volition-suppressing parental style related to decreased autonomy need satisfaction, which in turn related to reactance and both internalizing and externalizing problems. Van Petegem, Soenens et al. (2015) further showed that there was no curvilinear association between volition-supportive parenting and problem behaviors in this sample of at-risk youth, a finding contradicting the assumption that at least moderate levels of control would be needed to protect at-risk youth from problematic

development. Even with these vulnerable adolescents, more support for volitional functioning simply seems to be better.

More research is needed, however, to address the question of exactly how these adolescents' need for autonomy can be nurtured. Although subjective experiences of volition and authenticity seem as important for vulnerable, relative to non-vulnerable, adolescents, there is a need for further research about the specific ways in which socialization figures (parents, teachers, counselors) can contribute to these experiences. Do these youths simply need stronger doses of contextual support for autonomy? Or are there different means to support their volition? Qualitative research could yield more detailed insight in the different manifestations of the support of volition among vulnerable adolescents and to youth in high-risk contexts.

Intermediate summary. The question whether there are limits to how much autonomy is good for adolescents needs to be answered differently depending on how autonomy is conceptualized. With a conceptualization of autonomy as independence, caution is warranted because too much independence may put adolescents at risk for problem behaviors, in particular when they are vulnerable to problem behaviors or when they are in a high-risk environment. When autonomy is conceptualized as volitional functioning, the sky is the limit. More experiences of volition and self-endorsement are indicative of adolescents' well-being and behavioral adjustment, even when adolescents are in high-risk social contexts.

Autonomy and relatedness: A difficult marriage?

Autonomy as independence. A central question in the literature on autonomy is whether autonomy can come at the cost of interpersonal relatedness (Goossens, 2006; Guisinger and Blatt, 1994; Hill and Holmbeck, 1986; Zimmer-Gembeck and Collins, 2003). If autonomy is defined as independence, autonomy can indeed stand in a conflictual relation with building and maintaining close and intimate relationships. The trade-off between autonomy and relatedness would manifest most strongly at very high levels of independence: the more adolescents pursue and achieve independence, the more they are at risk of distancing from parents or even alienating from the social environment, resulting in decreased parent-adolescent relatedness and connection (Beyers et al., 2003; Frank, Avery, and Laman, 1988; Ryan and Lynch, 1989).

This potential tension between autonomy and relatedness is reflected in the widespread notion that autonomy and relatedness need to be *balanced* to foster adaptive development (e.g., Koepke and Denissen, 2012; Kroger, 2004; Grotevant and Cooper, 1986; Steinberg, 1990; see Kansky et al., Chapter 2, this volume). While the metaphor of a balance is typically used to indicate that, ideally, adolescents display both autonomy and relatedness, when taken literally the notion of a balance denotes the fact that autonomy and relatedness both need to be present in a moderate degree. When one side of the balance (i.e., either autonomy or relatedness)

is very high, this would lead to a decrease at the other side of the balance, possibly resulting in maladjustment.

Autonomy as volition. When autonomy is defined as volitional functioning, the marriage between autonomy and relatedness is less difficult and conflicted. According to SDT, volitional functioning and relatedness are highly compatible and even mutually reinforce one another to foster well-being and healthy interpersonal adjustment (Deci and Ryan, 2014; La Guardia and Patrick, 2008). To feel a genuine sense of relatedness in close relationships, it is important for people to experience that there is room to be themselves (i.e., to experience autonomy need satisfaction). Conversely, this sense of volition and authenticity in relationships will emerge only when the relationship is rooted in a basis of unconditional love and care. As a result, adolescents' well-being and social adjustment would be maximized if both the needs for autonomy and relatedness are simultaneously satisfied in high doses. There is no necessary tension or trade-off between relatedness and autonomy as volition: both psychological needs can be natural allies, and when they are then they promote healthy development in a synergistic fashion.

In line with the hypothesized harmony between volition and relatedness and their complementary growth-promoting role, several studies documented positive and strong associations (i.e., in the range between .40 and .60) between general assessments of the needs for autonomy and relatedness in adolescents (e.g., Chen et al., 2015; Vansteenkiste, Lens, Soenens, and Luyckx, 2006; Veronneau et al., 2005). The interplay between autonomy as volition and relatedness also has been examined in more specific relationships, such as the parent-adolescent relationship, friendships, or romantic relationships. In several samples of late adolescents, La Guardia, Ryan, Couchman, and Deci (2000) showed that attachment security in different types of relationships (with parents, best friends, and romantic partners) was predicted by satisfaction of the need for autonomy. To experience a deep sense of connection and security in relationships with others, it is important to feel supported in one's volition and to experience room for authenticity. Experiences of volition also predict the extent to which one partner supports the other partner's relatedness (Hadden, Rodriguez, Knee, and Porter, 2015). Thus, volition and relatedness are closely intertwined and mutually reinforcing within and between partners in close relationships.

Given the dynamic and positive interplay between autonomy (defined as volition) and relatedness, it should come as no surprise that extensive research has demonstrated that satisfaction of both the need for autonomy and the need for relatedness in close relationships is conducive to well-being and relationship satisfaction (Deci and Ryan, 2014; La Guardia and Patrick, 2008; Patrick, Knee, Canevello, and Lonsbary, 2007). Studies have demonstrated that satisfaction of both needs is related uniquely to adolescents' well-being, indicating that high levels of both needs are required to foster adjustment (e.g., Emery et al., 2015; Veronneau et al., 2005). Only a few studies examined interactive effects of the needs for autonomy and relatedness and none of them obtained systematic evidence for the notion

of a trade-off. When interactions were found they revealed a different type of interplay, with high autonomy compensating for low relatedness (instead of suppressing the effect of relatedness) (e.g., Vansteenkiste et al., 2006).

The combined importance of autonomy and relatedness is also demonstrated by the fact that parents' capacity to nurture these needs forecasts quality of relationships outside the family (e.g., relationships with peers and romantic relationships; see Allen and Loeb, 2015; Kansky et al., Chapter 2, and Zimmer-Gembeck et al., Chapter 8, this volume). For instance, Kanat-Maymon and Assor (2010) demonstrated that a combination of high maternal warmth and controllingness was related to empathic deficits in romantic relationships, likely because this combination of maternal behaviors created tension between the needs for autonomy and relatedness.

Intermediate summary. Concerns regarding a trade-off between autonomy and relatedness are justified mainly when autonomy is defined as independence. In contrast, when autonomy is defined as volitional functioning, there is a mutual and reciprocally reinforcing interplay between autonomy and relatedness. Autonomy as volition and relatedness are both uniquely important for adolescents' well-being and relationship satisfaction. Research has even begun to demonstrate that the benefits of autonomy and relatedness in relationships with key socialization figures such as parents carry over to relationships outside the family such as peers, friends, and romantic partners (see Zimmer-Gembeck et al., Chapter 8, this volume).

Is autonomy at odds with morality and responsibility?

Autonomy as independence. Much like some scholars have warned about a trade-off between autonomy and relatedness, concerns have been raised about a trade-off between autonomy and moral functioning. The more people prioritize their own goals and strive for self-reliance, the greater the risk of developing a selfish orientation where concern and responsibility for other people's welfare are secondary to one's own interests (Agnew, 1984; Chen, 2010; Jensen, 1997; Schwartz, 2000). Particularly in Western societies, where individualism is highly valued, autonomy may take the shape of an unrestrained desire to be free, possibly leading to a preoccupation with one's self-interest and to a neglect of responsibilities in the family and in the broader community (Markus and Kitayama, 1991).

In our view, the potential moral deficits associated with autonomy would apply especially to autonomy as independence. Indeed, in this case, there is a potential tension between the pursuit of autonomy and the adoption of rules and values promoted by socialization figures. This is because adolescents pursuing independence would want to liberate themselves from externally offered rules and guidelines, instead making up their own rules and determining their own values. Because parental rules and values represent one important route toward moral socialization (Grusec and Goodnow, 1994; Maccoby, 2014), autonomy understood as independence can be at odds with healthy moral development.

Consistent with these concerns, quite a few studies have demonstrated associations between independent decision-making and indicators of hampered moral functioning, including delinquency and rule-breaking behavior (e.g., Dornbusch et al., 1985; Lamborn, Dornbusch, and Steinberg, 1996; Van Petegem et al., 2012). Further, when adolescents keep much information to themselves rather than disclosing this information to parents—which can be interpreted as an attempt to take distance from parents and to safeguard their independence (Finkenauer, Engels, and Meeus, 2002)—they display more externalizing problems (Frijns, Keijsers, Branje, and Meeus, 2010; Keijsers, Frijns, Branje, and Meeus, 2009; Kerr and Stattin, 2000).

Autonomy as volition. With a conceptualization of autonomy as volitional functioning, such tension between autonomy and morality is less likely to exist. Moral functioning would even be integral to autonomy because in SDT it is assumed that, under supportive circumstances, people are naturally inclined to integrate themselves into the social matrix and to start owning societally offered norms, values, and guidelines (Ryan and Deci, 2000; Ryan and Hawley, 2016). To the extent they achieve such ownership, they would volitionally take responsibility for their actions and display altruism towards others. The assumption of such a prosocial tendency in SDT is consistent with recent developmental research documenting early moral sensitivity already in infancy (Thompson and Newton, 2013).

Conditions that support individuals' volition, and by extension also their psychological needs for competence and relatedness, would allow this natural sensitivity for morality and this inclination towards social integration to unfold, thereby giving rise to an empathic, prosocial, and altruistic interpersonal orientation. In contrast, under need-thwarting circumstances, individuals' vulnerabilities, including their risk for immoral behavior, would be awakened (Vansteenkiste and Ryan, 2013). Specifically, when the need for autonomy is frustrated (resulting in feelings of pressure and obligation) people would be functioning more defensively and become more sensitive for interpersonal threats (Deci and Ryan, 2000; Hodgins, Yacko, and Gottlieb, 2006). As a consequence, individuals' thresholds for anger, aggression, and acting out would be lowered. Also, rules and restrictions would then easily be perceived as illegitimate restrictions of one's freedom, giving rise to feelings of reactance and a tendency to reject socialization figures' authority (Van Petegem, Soenens et al., 2015). Such resistance against authority figures would forestall the adoption of social and moral values, thereby undermining adolescents' moral development and potentially giving rise to problems to impulsivity and aggression (Ryan et al., 2016; Vansteenkiste and Ryan, 2013).

Consistent with the SDT-based view on autonomy and moral functioning, autonomy need satisfaction and its contextual support were found to predict prosocial behavior (Gagné, 2003). For instance, late adolescent athletes, who perceived their coach to support their autonomy (defined as volitional functioning) and who were more autonomously motivated for their sports reported engaging in more prosocial behavior (Hodge and Lonsdale, 2011). Parental support for autonomy and subsequent experiences of autonomy need satisfaction also were found to lower the risk

of cyberbullying in adolescents, effects that were mediated by increased empathic concern for other people (Fousiani et al., 2016). Bureau and Mageau (2014) found that autonomy-supportive parents had adolescents who identified more strongly with the value for honesty and who saw more benefits in telling the truth to parents. In contrast, experiences of pressure (heteronomy) and contextual thwarting of the need for autonomy are related to aggression and externalizing problems, with processes such as reactance (Van Petegem, Soenens et al., 2015), moral disengagement (Delrue, Vansteenkiste, Mouratidis, Van de Broeck, and Haerens, 2016), and dehumanization (Moller and Deci, 2010) accounting for these associations.

An important reason why volitional functioning contributes to moral behavior is that adolescents can maintain a sense of volition even if they adhere to social values and rules, many of which have moral relevance. That is, to the extent that adolescents have internalized (i.e., accepted) rules introduced by socialization figures, they will follow them for more self-endorsed reasons as they have achieved a sense of ownership over the rules (Deci, Eghrari, Patrick, and Leone, 1994; Grolnick, Deci, and Ryan, 1997; Joussemet, Landry, and Koestner, 2008). Such deep internalization of rules and regulations is fostered in a context high on structure and autonomy-support. Indeed, for children to start adopting rules and regulations, socializing agents need to be clear about their expectations. Yet, they also need to support adolescents' volition such that adolescents come to willingly endorse the regulations. Congruent with this claim, adolescent perceived autonomy-supportive parental communication about moral rules has been found to predict increasing internalization of these rules (Roth, 2008; Vansteenkiste, Soenens, Van Petegem, and Duriez, 2014). In turn, internalization of morally relevant behavior (e.g., donating money to charity and volunteering) predicts more prosocial behavior (Barry, Padilla-Walker, Madsen, and Nelson, 2008; Hardy, Dollahite, Johnson, and Christensen, 2015).

Intermediate summary. While the pursuit and display of high levels of independence (especially when independence is displayed prematurely; Dishion et al., 2004) may be hazardous to adolescents' moral development and behavior, volitional functioning is fully consistent with and even contributes to social responsibility and prosocial behavior. This is because conditions that support volitional functioning nurture children's inherent and natural tendency to seek social integration and to be altruistic. Also, volitional functioning can be displayed even when adhering to externally introduced rules and values. Through the process of internalization, adolescents can come to embrace the value of moral principles and regulations, thereby taking up responsibility for their actions and adopting a prosocial orientation in a volitional fashion.

Can parental encouragement of autonomy go hand-in-hand with rule-setting?

Autonomy as independence. The question of whether and how autonomy plays a role in moral development also raises questions about the role of parents in moral

socialization. If parents are supposed to encourage autonomy, can they still introduce rules and set limits to adolescents' behavior? With a conceptualization of autonomy as independence, this is not self-evident because independence and negative freedom imply almost by definition an absence of rules, regulations, and restrictions. Parental promotion of independence involves encouraging adolescents to become self-reliant and to solve problems without parental guidance (Silk, Morris, Kanaya, and Steinberg, 2003; Steinberg, 2002). Parents focusing on independence may feel that rules and limit-setting stifle adolescents' self-reliance. Parents highlighting the importance of independence may even think that it is no longer their task to set rules and to supervise their adolescent's behavior. At their age, adolescents should know what is allowed and they should be old enough to face the consequences when they trespass norms.

However, theory and research suggest that a lack of parental regulation renders adolescents vulnerable to problem behavior (Barber, Stolz, and Olsen, 2005). One reason why parents still need to take an active role in the regulation of behavior is that the neuropsychological processes involved in self-regulation and executive functioning are still strongly developing during adolescence (Steinberg, 2007). Because maturation of the pre-frontal brain regions, which are important in self-regulatory abilities, continues well into young adulthood, adolescents are at heightened risk for impulsivity and for impaired emotion regulation (Casey and Jones, 2010). Accordingly, parents of adolescents face the challenge of nurturing autonomy while at the same time coaching their child in the process of regulating behavior and coping with negative emotions. To deal with this challenge effectively, parents need to do more than simply highlighting the importance of independence.

Autonomy as volition. In SDT, parental support for autonomy is defined as the promotion of volitional functioning. Autonomy-supportive parenting entails various practices that contribute to children's experiences of self-endorsement and psychological freedom (Grolnick et al., 1997; Chapter 5, this volume; Joussemet et al., 2008; Ryan et al., 2016; Soenens et al., 2007), including the display of an active interest in children's experiences, acknowledgment of the child's feelings (and negative feelings in particular), the provision of meaningful choices, the encouragement of initiative, and the provision of a personally relevant rationale when choices are limited (Deci et al., 1994; Vansteenkiste and Soenens, 2015). Autonomy-supportive parents essentially take the child's frame of reference, thereby adopting an empathic stance and trying to provide choices, opportunities for initiative, and explanations that correspond to the child's interests, values, or preferences.

Importantly, parental promotion of volitional functioning is not incompatible with parental rule-setting. In SDT, clear communication of rules is considered one element of parental structure (i.e., parental practices that support children's competence; Farkas and Grolnick, 2010; Grolnick et al., Chapter 5, this volume). Parents can communicate rules and still support adolescents' autonomy (defined as volitional functioning); for instance, by providing a meaningful rationale for the rule and by acknowledging the adolescent's opinion (and perhaps even negative

feelings) regarding the rule. This autonomy-supportive style of introducing rules contributes to the effectiveness of parental rule-setting and to long-term adherence to rules because it fosters internalization of the importance and personal relevance of rules (Koestner, Ryan, Bernieri, and Holt, 1984). For instance, Vansteenkiste et al. (2014) showed that an autonomy-supportive maternal style of communicating about moral prohibitions was predictive of increases in adolescents' internalization of these moral prohibitions. When mothers were perceived as autonomy-supportive, adolescents increasingly displayed personal endorsement of the moral prohibitions. This acceptance of moral rules, in turn, predicted increases in perceived maternal reliance on an autonomy-supportive style. Apparently, when adolescents identify more readily with the importance of moral rules, it also becomes easier for parents to communicate about these rules in an autonomy-supportive way.

Research has shown that an autonomy-supportive style of introducing rules is effective not only in the moral domain but even in domains that are personal to adolescents and that are considered by many adolescents as beyond parental jurisdiction, such as friendships. Soenens, Vansteenkiste, and Niemiec (2009) found that an autonomy-supportive parental style of prohibiting certain friendships was related to internalization of the prohibition and to subsequent lower affiliation with deviant friends. Thus, an autonomy-supportive style may contribute to adolescents' understanding of the parents' perspective and to acceptance of rules even in domains that are controversial and a common source for parent-adolescent conflicts.

Thus, autonomy-support (defined as support for volitional functioning) can be (and ideally is) combined with clear communication of rules and with other features of structure, including the provision of help and advice (Farkas and Grolnick, 2010; Vansteenkiste and Soenens, 2015). The advantage of this combination of structure and autonomy-support is that parents will tailor their rules, expectations, and advice to the mindset, capacities, and needs of the adolescent: instead of setting rigid and parent-driven expectations and instead of giving unwanted advice, autonomy-supportive parents ask about the adolescent's point of view when introducing rules, acknowledge the adolescent's potential negative feelings (e.g., reactance) against the rules, and communicate expectations that are feasible given the adolescent's capacities. They also ask whether they can provide advice or input regarding problems (e.g., when an adolescent got involved in a conflict or fight with peers), and provide help mainly when solicited by the adolescent. By combining structure with support for volitional functioning, parents nurture not only adolescents' need for autonomy but also their need for competence.

Intermediate summary. With the promotion of independence, it may at times be difficult for parents to play an active role in rule-setting. Parents may experience that it is difficult to require that adolescents stand on their own two feet while at the same time asking that they adhere to parental rules. With a conceptualization of parental autonomy-support as the promotion of volitional functioning, support for autonomy is not at odds with parental advice, coaching, and input nor with parental rule-setting. The combination of clear rules and an autonomy-supportive

communication style even contributes most strongly to adolescents' internalization of parental rules, including rules in the moral domain. Thus, parental promotion of volitional functioning helps parents to reconcile the goals of socializing adolescents and of strengthening adolescents' autonomy, goals that are sometimes considered to be antithetical.

Are the benefits of autonomy a privilege of the West?

Autonomy as independence. There is a longstanding debate in cross-cultural psychology about the meaning and (mal)adaptive role of autonomy for different cultural groups, with several scholars being critical of the alleged beneficial role of autonomy in non-Western cultures and nations. A prominent model is Markus and Kitayama's (2003) cultural agency model, which distinguishes between disjoint and conjoint models of agency. In disjoint models, agency is constructed as an independent entity that is disconnected from others. In contrast, in conjoint models, agency is constructed in terms of meeting social obligations and engaging in social requirements. Depending on the prevailing model of agency, the self is expressed either through the pursuit of independence, unique preferences, and personal achievement (disjoint models) or through harmonious relationships with in-group members (conjoint models).

In this view, autonomy is equated with independence and the pursuit of independence is seen as antagonistic to the tendency to conform to existing norms, rules, and external influences (Witkin and Berry, 1975). Consistent with these claims, studies have shown that individuals living in societies characterized by a conjoint model of agency are more likely to conform to social rules and expectations (Cialdini, Wosinska, Barrett, Butner, and Gornik-Durose, 1999; Feldman and Rosenthal, 1991; Kim and Markus, 1999). Further, cross-cultural scholars have suggested that the benefits of autonomy would be limited to individuals living in a culture that favors a disjoint model of agency (e.g., Cross, Gore, and Morris, 2003; Iyengar and Lepper, 1999; Oishi, 2000).

When autonomy is defined as independence, culture may indeed play a moderating role such that the beneficial effects of autonomy on adolescent development are observed only in the West. Illustrating the cultural specificity of the prevalence and effects of independence, Qin, Pomerantz, and Wang (2009) reported that US adolescents showed higher initial levels and stronger increases in independent decision-making in the transition from 7th to 8th grade than Chinese adolescents. Moreover, although higher initial levels of independent decision-making related to enhanced emotional functioning in both China and the US, increases in independent decision-making were related to increases in well-being only in US adolescents.

Autonomy as volition. As noted above, when autonomy is defined as volitional functioning, autonomy is not necessarily at odds with social expectations, conformity, and interdependent relationships. Adolescents can volitionally depend on external and culturally determined guidelines and inputs, given they have internalized

them. The experiences of authenticity and of owning one's actions (i.e., experiences of autonomy need satisfaction) emanating from this process of internalization are assumed to be universally important for well-being (Deci and Ryan, 2000).

Research has confirmed that people can internalize both individualistic and collectivistic practices and, hence, display self-endorsement and volitional functioning with regard to various cultural values (Chirkov, Ryan, Kim, and Kaplan, 2003). Moreover, the internalization of cultural practices was found to predict well-being irrespective of the type of practices involved and irrespective of individuals' cultural background. In samples of late adolescents (college students) from four different nations (US, Russia, Korea, and Turkey), Chirkov et al. (2003) showed that internalization of any type of cultural practices was related positively to well-being. Similar results were reported by Chirkov, Ryan, and Willness (2005) in samples of Brazilian and Canadian college students.

Building on this research, Chen et al. (2013) examined Chinese adolescents' reasons for taking independent decisions or for relying on their parents for input and advice. Much like the Belgian adolescents sampled in Van Petegem et al. (2012), Chinese adolescents' well-being did not so much vary as a function of their level of independence but did vary substantially as a function of the type of motives for making (in)dependent decisions. Specifically, self-endorsed (internalized) reasons for both independence and dependence predicted more well-being (Chen et al., 2013). These findings are important as they indicate that if autonomy is defined and assessed as volition, also Chinese adolescents benefit. Notably, not only self-endorsed dependency was predictive of well-being, but also self-endorsed independence, in spite of the fact these adolescents grew up in a collectivist culture.

Similar findings have been reported with respect to the need for autonomy, which has been shown to predict higher well-being in cultures across the globe (Sheldon et al., 2004; Sheldon, Cheng, and Hilpert, 2011; Vansteenkiste et al., 2006). This hypothesis was rigorously tested by Chen et al. (2015), who found autonomy need satisfaction to yield unique benefits (above and beyond competence and relatedness) in a large cross-cultural sample, with the association being equivalent among Belgian, Chinese, American, and Peruvian late adolescents.

Importantly, SDT's claims about the universally adaptive role of autonomy do not preclude the possibility of cross-cultural differences in the way contextual support for autonomy is perceived (Deci and Ryan, 1987; Patall and Yang Hooper, Chapter 7, this volume; Soenens, Vansteenkiste, and Van Petegem, 2015; Grolnick et al., Chapter 5, this volume). That is, adolescents' cultural orientation may affect the way potentially need-supportive or need-thwarting practices are interpreted. For example, Chao and Aque (2009) reported that Asian adolescents feel less angry about parents using autonomy-suppressive (i.e., psychologically controlling) tactics compared with European American adolescents. However, subjective experiences of autonomy-suppressing parenting have been found to predict adolescents' ill-being across cultures (e.g., Chirkov and Ryan, 2001). Hence, while culture may affect the appraisal of contextual influences on the need for autonomy, the

subjective experience of volition following from contextual autonomy support is fundamental to adolescents' well-being and universally important.

Intermediate summary. Because independence contrasts almost by definition with values and practices considered important in collectivist societies (such as conformity, obedience, and social harmony), cross-cultural and developmental researchers have argued that autonomy (when defined as independence) is relevant and potentially beneficial to adolescents' development only in the West. Research has shown indeed that independent decision-making is less prevalent in collectivist cultures and that effects of independence are not unequivocal in such cultures. In contrast, when autonomy is defined as volitional functioning, autonomy is relevant and essential for well-being across cultures. Both more self-endorsed (i.e., internalized) enactment of cultural practices and the experience of autonomy need satisfaction have been shown to relate to higher well-being across the globe.

Conclusion

The concept of autonomy is probably one of the most important and at the same time enigmatic concepts in the psychology of adolescent development. Despite its rich theoretical history, different uses of the term have led to a complex and sometimes seemingly contradictory literature, with different implications for parenting practices. In this chapter we argued that a distinction between independence and volitional functioning can help to bring clarity to many of these questions. We believe it is of paramount importance for scholars studying adolescent development to be as clear and explicit as possible about their conceptualization of autonomy. This is because the difference between independence and volition has important implications for the role assigned to autonomy in adolescents' psychosocial adjustment, social development, and moral behavior, as well as for the way micro-contexts (e.g., parents) and macro-contexts (e.g., culture) can affect autonomy.

At the same time, we argue for a more integrated approach to studying adolescent autonomy, where scholars do not focus exclusively on one specific conceptualization of autonomy but instead address their interplay and combined role in adolescent development. Although in this chapter we have argued that autonomy-defined-as-volition has more straightforward and robust positive associations with adolescents' psychosocial adjustment than autonomy-defined-as-independence, we strongly recommend to still give a central place to independence in future research on adolescent autonomy. Adolescents' desire for more independence is very real, as is their tendency to actually become more independent and self-reliant as they grow older. Also, parents undeniably face the challenge of responding adequately to adolescents' distance-taking and demands for increasing independence. As such, it would be misguided to downplay the importance of independence in adolescent development.

We believe that a fruitful approach for future research is to systematically examine the conjoint role of adolescent independence and volition. Effects of

independence are likely to depend on their combined presence (or even regulation by) experiences and motives reflecting volition. When adolescents feel pressured (either from within or from external demands for self-reliance) to be independent, they are unlikely to reap the benefits of achieving greater independence. They might even display maladjustment, as manifested in social isolation, reactance, and problem behaviors. When, instead, adolescents strive for independence for volitional reasons and with parental support for volitional functioning, they are more likely to experience feelings of authenticity, psychological freedom, and self-endorsement. Such experiences ensuing from a volitional regulation of independence strengthen children's ability to cope with the myriad challenges of adolescence and contribute in a lasting way to adolescents' mental health and quality of social relationships.

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